



Abhinav Lal
abhinav.lal@thinkdigit.com

Gleaning orange, tearing air, I cut right to avoid an oncoming truck on the two-lane black top winding through an ochre landscape, blip the hand-brake, and point my McLaren F1 at the apex, hold down the nitrous and drift 200 metres before straightening into a gate that serves as my shortcut to the other side of the next curve, fusing sand onto the once slick rubber of my squealing tires.

Sounds familiar...Nope it's not Burnout, no matter

what the imagery wants you to believe. Those are real performance and super cars licensed by their manufacturers, just converted into toys using pixels and physics modeling. Engineered to accept my inputs, and to create an atmosphere that enables unparalleled feats of my driving ability across the verisimilitude of topographies Seacrest County seems to offer. Need For Speed: Hot Pursuit from Criterion Games – flashing lights in my rear view mirror, and all that.

While you can't chain burnouts together, you sure

can pull off moves just as spectacular as in the Burnout series, controlling drifts while swerving between lanes at 234 kmph, with physics benevolently forgiving you for hitting nitrous too early on the exits. Do it while turning, and though you won't actually gain speed like Burnout, or spin out like Underground 2, you maintain a nice and steady speed through the corner instead – no wheelspins here.

A good way to describe the game's controls and gameplay – very forgiving and stunningly fun – simplifying everything down till your fear-

less coming to grips with the game's artificial physics is all it takes. You will be doing all the tricks in no time, gaining nitrous without thinking.

The graphics of the game are very realistic, enough so that you don't feel too stunned looking around, though the motion blur in turbo mode is something to behold. The cars are exquisitely modeled, and the scenery is flawless, with barely any superfluous elements like lens flares and smoke to distract. No over-saturation, no funky ShowTime.

The game is set in Seacrest County, a place that offers